MUSIC ▼

Presents from the Past

On the new album, Tarun Balani explores his Sindhi heritage and the community's collective lived experience

Tarun Balani found the inspiration for his new album *Kadahin Milandaa-sin* at home—in the paintings, photographs and writings of his late grandfather whom he had never met. He found it in the music of Sindhi singers such as Haider Rind and Allan Faqir, introduced to him by his father, who passed away last year. He found it in his ancestral house in New Delhi's Lajpat Nagar in which his studio takes up the same place his granddad used as a workspace. And he found it in the stories of countless Sindhi families such as his own who bear the generational trauma of Partition.

"It's incredible how despite displacement, we've not played the victim card," says Balani of the community. For the drummer, jazz composer and electronic music producer who prefers to be known as a "sonic storyteller", the album is an exploration of cultural heritage and an endeavour to both mourn and celebrate losses and legacies.

On the wistful instrumental record—the Sindhi title of which translates to 'When will we meet?' and is derived from a line in poet Shaikh Ayaz's verse 'Tiri Pawanda'—Sindhi folk music is a point of interpretation rather than a sonic reference for him and his band Dharma, which features the NY-based trio: trumpet player Adam O'Farrill, guitarist Olli Hirvonen and pianist Sharik Hasan.

The visual identity of *Kadahin...* pays more direct tribute. The cover is a photograph of Balani's grandfather. For the promotional photo shoot, he wore a traditional Sindhi cap and his father's shawl, purchased in Pakistan in the early 1990s. In the images, Balani's head is turned sideways. "I'm looking over my shoulder to acknowledge my ancestors," he says. "I've been told my music is very cinematic. That's a great compliment. Because I want people to be moved by the music." ■

—Amit Gurbaxani







SONIC YOUTH
The Sindhi title of Balani's new album translates to 'When will we meet?'





BOOKS ▼

DOG STORY

The first in a graphic novel series based on the movie *Lakadbaggha* is out

The 2023 action film *Lakadbaggha*—based on an animal-lover vigilante—now has its own comic book. *Lakadbaggha: The Prologue* is illustrated by the American artist Brittain Peck, and takes you right into the thick of the action at Kolkata's Khidirpur docks. "One of my favourite parts is doing research and development as I design the characters, location and details that will make up the world of the story. That part was especially exciting with this project because I love the variety of characters and Kolkata is such a visually interesting location," says Peck. The comic is firmly rooted in the Lakadbaggha universe, with Peck drawing inspiration "from their nearly every aspect, including the music, lighting, costumes and settings". The illustrations are in the *ligne claire* ('clear line') tradition pioneered by Hergé, the colour palette distinctly noir. Peck shares a co-creator credit with Anshuman Jha, who played the lead character Arjun Bakshi in the movie. Both are comic buffs. "In this first prologue book, we were both excited to be creating a part of Arjun's story with the attack at the docks that is mentioned at the beginning of the film but not seen," says Peck. ■

LAKADBAGGHA: THE PROLOGUE TAKES YOU RIGHT INTO THE **THICK OF THE ACTION** AT KOLKATA'S KHIDIRPUR DOCKS

—Amit Dixit